



OAKRIDGE INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL
HYDERABAD, BACHUPALLY
A NORD ANGLIA EDUCATION SCHOOL



BACKGROUND GUIDE



DISEC

Agenda: Addressing the Nuclearization of South Asia and advancing the risk reduction measures between India and Pakistan.



Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

We are very pleased to welcome you to the simulation of the **UNGA: DISEC** at **OakB MUN 2026**. It is an honour to serve as your Executive Board for the duration of the conference. This Background Guide is designed to give you an insight into the case at hand, so we hope this acts as only a **catalyst** for furthering your research and not limited to just this guide. Please refer to it carefully. Remember, a thorough understanding of the problem is the first step to solving it.

Do understand that this Background Guide is in no way exhaustive and is only meant to provide you with enough background information to establish a platform for beginning the research. Delegates are highly recommended to do a good amount of research beyond what is covered in the Guide. The guide cannot be used as proof during the committee proceedings under any circumstances.

We understand that MUN conferences can be an overwhelming experience for first-timers but it must be noted that our aspirations from the delegates are not how experienced or articulate they are. Rather, we want to see how one manages the balance to respect disparities and differences of opinion and work around this while extending their foreign policy to present comprehensive solutions without compromising on their self-interests and initiate consensus building.

New ideas are by their very nature disruptive, but far less disruptive than a world set against the backdrop of stereotypes and regional instability due to which reform is essential in policy making and conflict resolution. At any point during your research, do not hesitate to contact the Executive Board Members for clarifications or in case you need help in any other aspect. We look forward to a fruitful discussion and an enriching experience with all of you.

Best regards,

Eswar Chava Harshith Kosaraju Rohil Dewani



Chairperson Vice Chairperson Rapporteur

Important Points to Remember

A few aspects that delegates should keep in mind while preparing:

Procedure: The purpose of putting in procedural rules in any committee is to ensure a more organized and efficient debate. The committee will follow the UNA-USA Rules of Procedure. Although the Executive Board shall be fairly strict with the Rules of Procedure, the discussion of the agenda will be the main priority. So, delegates are advised not to restrict their statements due to hesitation regarding procedure.

Foreign Policy: Following the foreign policy of one's country is the most important aspect of a Model UN Conference. This is what essentially differentiates a Model UN from other debating formats. To violate one's foreign policy without adequate reason is one of the worst mistakes a delegate can make.

Role of the Executive Board: The Executive Board is appointed to facilitate debate. The committee shall decide the direction and flow of debate. The delegates are the ones who constitute the committee and hence must be uninhibited while presenting their opinions/stance on any issue. However, the Executive Board may put forward questions and/or ask for clarifications at all points of time to further debate and test participants.

Nature of Source/Evidence: This Background Guide is meant solely for research purposes and must not be cited as evidence to substantiate statements made during the conference. Evidence or proof for substantiating statements made during formal debate is acceptable from the following sources:

a. **United Nations:** Documents and findings by the United Nations or any related UN body is held as a credible proof to support a claim or argument. Multilateral Organizations: Documents from international organizations like OIC, NATO, SAARC, BRICS, EU, ASEAN, the International Court of Justice, etc. may also be presented as credible sources of information.



b. **Government Reports:** These reports can be used in a similar way as the State Operated News Agencies reports and can, in all circumstances, be denied by another country.

c. **News Sources:**

1. Reuters: Any Reuters article that clearly makes mention of the fact or is in contradiction of the fact being stated by a delegate in council.

2. State operated News Agencies: These reports can be used in the support of or against the State that owns the News Agency. These reports, if credible or substantial enough, can be used in support of or against any country as such but in that situation, may be denied by any other country in the council. Some examples are - RIA Novosti (Russian Federation), Xinhua News Agency (People's Republic of China), etc.

***Please Note: Reports from NGOs working with UNESCO, UNICEF and other UN bodies will be accepted . **Under no circumstances will sources like Wikipedia, or newspapers like the Guardian, Times of India, etc. be accepted.** However, notwithstanding the criteria for acceptance of sources and evidence, delegates are still free to quote/cite from any source as they deem fit as a part of their statements.

Guidelines

Read the entirety of the background guide in the order it was written. Make sure to highlight the names of specific treaties, documents, resolutions, conventions, international bodies, events and any other specific incidents so that you can get back to them later and do a lot more thorough research.

Understand some of the basic details regarding the country that you've been allotted whether this be the capital, current affairs regarding geopolitical situation, political hierarchy etc. While not strictly necessary, you never know when this can turn out to be handy. Geography Now's A - Z Country List has been a particularly helpful resource for this.

Use a search engine of your choice to create as many tabs as possible for the highlighted terms from your background guide. Wikipedia or a YouTube video act as a great way to get a brief summary of the incidents



at hand but such sources (especially Wikipedia articles) cannot be used in committee as sources.

Delve into deeper research regarding the particular position of your allocation with the agenda at hand. Try searching for the voting stances of your allocation in related conventions and understanding the reasons for voting as so. UN Press Releases are also a helpful source for this matter.

Find the website for the foreign ministry of the country you have been assigned alongside the "Permanent Mission of COUNTRY to the United Nations" website and search for a key term relating to the agenda, this should often give you statements from recent press conferences or UN committee sessions that can act as valuable sources of information in forming a stance.

Keep a handy copy of the Charter of the United Nations, whether as a .pdf file extension or a physical copy works. This contains the founding principles of the United Nations and contains articles that lay out the mandate of the six bodies that the United Nations is primarily divided into. Spend some additional time researching the specific mandate and functions of the committee that you have been assigned.

The Executive Board may ask for the source of a statement that a delegate makes in committee either during a Point of Order circumstance or if said statement stands to be of interest to the Executive Board. Therefore, it is recommended that delegates keep track of their sources when making / disputing a claim and also ensure their validity. Please do remember that while you as a delegate are allowed to cite any source you wish during committee.

Hierarchy of evidence

Evidence can be presented from a wide variety of sources, but not all sources are treated as equal. Here's the hierarchy in which evidence is categorised:

Tier 1 : Includes any publication, statement, resolution, or document released by any of the Nations' official organs or committees; any publication, statement, or document released by a UN member state in



its own capacity. The evidence falling in this tier is considered most reliable during the simulation.

Tier 2 : Includes: any news article published by any official media source that is owned and controlled by a UN member state. E.g.: Xinhua News (China), Prasar Bharti (India), BBC (United Kingdom) etcetera. The evidence falling in this tier is considered sufficiently reliable in case no other evidence from any Tier 1 source is available on that particular fact, event, or situation.

Tier 3 : Includes: any publication from news sources of international repute such as Reuters, The New York Times, Agence-France Presse, etcetera. The evidence falling under this tier is considered the least reliable for the purposes of this simulation. Yet, if no better source is available in a certain scenario, it may be considered.

Foreign Policy and Foreign Relations

Foreign policy, in simple terms, is what your country aims to achieve in regard to the issue at hand or in general with its relations with other countries.

1. What role must foreign policy play in your research?

Understanding the foreign policy of your country must be a checkbox that you tick off at the very beginning of your research.

Your foreign policy should dictate everything from the arguments you make, the reasoning you give for making those arguments, and the actions you take in the Council.

2. Where do I look to find foreign policy?

Most of the time, foreign policy is not explicitly stated. It must be inferred from the actions and statements issued by the country. Reading the meeting records from previous meetings of UNSC (or any other UN body where your country might have spoken on the issue) is a great place to start. If such records are unavailable, look for statements from your country's Foreign Ministry (or equivalent like Ministry of External Affairs, Ministry for Foreign Affairs etcetera) and top leadership (PM, Pres., Secretary of State, Defence Minister).



Foreign Relations on the other hand refers to the diplomatic ties that one country has with another and considers elements such as the mutual presence of embassies, consulates, ambassadors & diplomatic dialogue. More often than not, foreign policy is what will be of your primary concern during the MUN, but it is important to also consider any extremities in your allotted country's foreign relations.

About the Committee

The United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) is one of the six organs of the United Nations (UN) and the primary policy making and representative organ of the United Nations where all of the 193 members of the UN are represented in the General Assembly. The Disarmament and International Security Committee is the first committee under the General Assembly that deals with disarmament, global challenges and threats to world peace.

The six committees of the United Nations General Assembly being:

First Committee - Disarmament & International Security,

Second Committee - Economic & Financial Council,

Third Committee - Social, Humanitarian & Cultural Issues,

Fourth Committee - Special Political & Decolonization Committee,

Fifth Committee - Administrative & Budgetary, &

Sixth Committee - Legal.

Mandate

The Disarmament and International Security Committee is mandated to address the nuclear, chemical, biological, conventional, etc. weapon proliferation and to deal with the issues threatening international security and peace.

DISEC makes recommendations to the UNGA regarding the resolutions and establishes principles and international cooperation between states to maintain global security. It considers all disarmament and international security matters within the scope of the Charter or relating



to the powers and functions of any other organ of the United Nations; the general principles of cooperation in the maintenance of international peace and security, as well as principles governing disarmament and the regulation of armaments; promotion of cooperative arrangements and measures aimed at strengthening stability through lower levels of armaments.

DISEC works closely with other UN bodies and agencies like the United Nations Office on Disarmament Affairs (UNODA) and International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). The First Committee sessions are structured into three distinctive stages:

1. General debate,
2. Thematic discussions, &
3. Action on Drafts.

Introduction

South Asia is the only region in the world where two nuclear-armed states share a live, unresolved territorial dispute, a long history of open war, and a border that has seen sustained militant violence for over three decades. India and Pakistan have fought four wars (1947, 1965, 1971, and the 1999 Kargil conflict) and one sustained 88-hour military exchange in May 2025, and have come close to a fifth full war on several other occasions. Both states possess nuclear weapons, both remain outside the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), and both have nuclear doctrines shaped less by global strategic theory than by their specific fear of one another.

South Asia is often described by nuclear strategists as the most dangerous threat in the world, for reasons distinct from the Cold War era, during which the US-Soviet rivalry that shaped most existing nuclear doctrine and arms control thinking. India and Pakistan share a land border with no meaningful strategic depth, have missile flight times measured in minutes rather than the roughly 30 minutes typical of intercontinental exchanges, lack the extensive verification and communication architecture that the US and Russia built up over decades, and face a recurring trigger for crisis such as cross-border militant violence that has no equivalence in the Cold War context.



This agenda asks the committee to look at this rivalry from two angles at once. The first is nuclearization itself: why India and Pakistan built nuclear weapons, what doctrines they now hold, and what legal and political status they occupy outside the NPT framework that governs the rest of the world's nuclear order. The second is risk reduction: what mechanisms currently exist to prevent a crisis between the two states from escalating to the nuclear level, how well those mechanisms have held up under real pressure (most recently in May 2025), and what more could realistically be built, given that neither state is likely to disarm and neither is likely to join the NPT as a non-nuclear-weapon state.

A miscalculation here could produce a humanitarian catastrophe on a scale unmatched by any conflict since the Second World War causing tens of millions of direct deaths and global climate effects (a nuclear-winter-type disruption to agriculture) severe enough to threaten famine well beyond South Asia itself. As of August 2026, India and Pakistan have no active comprehensive dialogue process; the Indus Waters Treaty, suspended by India after the April 2025 Pahalgam attack, remains in abeyance; and analysts are still debating what Operation Sindoor changed about the two countries' mutual understanding of escalation thresholds. Delegates should treat the situation as unresolved and evolving, not as settled history.

What constitutes the South Asia region?

The South Asia region, as defined by the United Nations, includes the following countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Iran, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka. This diverse region is characterized by complex geopolitical dynamics, unresolved territorial disputes, and the presence of nuclear-armed states, all of which have significant implications for the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation.

The geographical proximity of these countries, their shared history, and the interconnected nature of their security concerns make the South Asia region a critical area of focus for addressing the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation. The region has witnessed several conflicts and tensions, particularly between India and Pakistan, which have contributed to the heightened risk of nuclear escalation.



The South Asia region is home to two nuclear-armed states, India and Pakistan, which together possess an estimated 331 nuclear warheads as of 2022. The presence of these nuclear-armed states, coupled with the ongoing conflicts and territorial disputes, has heightened the risk of nuclear proliferation and the potential for catastrophic consequences in the event of a conflict.

The presence of ongoing conflicts, political instability, and weak governance in some areas of South Asia further exacerbates the challenges in addressing nuclear proliferation. The porous borders, lack of effective border controls, and the potential for corruption within nuclear facilities and programs heighten the risk of nuclear materials or technology being diverted to non-state actors or other countries seeking to acquire nuclear weapons capabilities.

Despite these challenges, the South Asia region has also made efforts towards regional cooperation and confidence-building measures. Organizations like the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) have provided a platform for dialogue and cooperation among the countries in the region. However, the lack of a comprehensive regional security framework or nuclear-weapon-free zone (NWFZ) in South Asia has hindered the development of trust and cooperation among the countries in addressing the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation.

Countries in the South Asia region that possess nuclear weapons

India and Pakistan are the two countries in the South Asia region that are known to possess nuclear weapons. Both countries have conducted successful nuclear tests and are believed to have developed substantial nuclear arsenals.

India conducted its first successful nuclear test in 1974, known as "Smiling Buddha," and is estimated to have a stockpile of around 156 nuclear warheads as of 2022. India's nuclear program has been driven by its perceived security threats, particularly from China, and its desire to maintain a credible deterrent. The country has also made efforts to



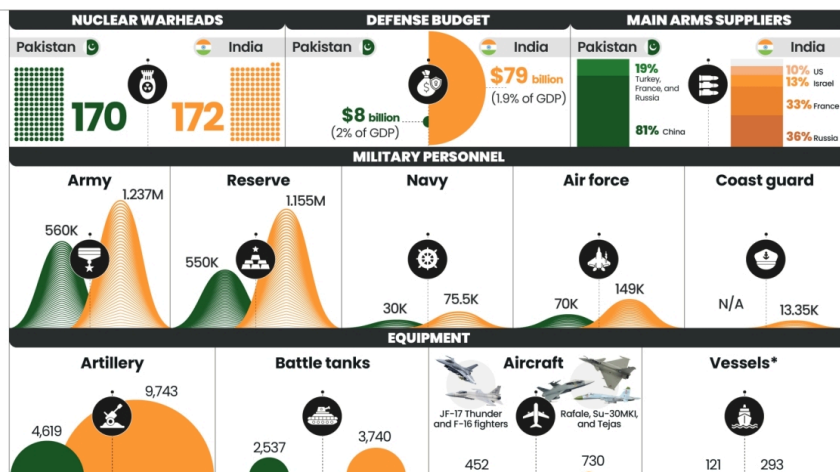
develop advanced nuclear technologies, including submarine-launched ballistic missiles and thermonuclear weapons.

According to the Federation of American Scientists (FAS), Pakistan conducted its first nuclear tests in 1998 in response to India's tests. Pakistan is estimated to have a stockpile of around 165 nuclear warheads as of 2022. Pakistan's nuclear program has been primarily motivated by its rivalry with India and the need to counter India's conventional and nuclear superiority. The country has also developed tactical nuclear weapons and short-range ballistic missiles to offset India's conventional military advantage.

The presence of these two nuclear-armed states in the South Asia region has heightened the risk of nuclear proliferation and the potential for catastrophic consequences in the event of a conflict. The unresolved territorial disputes, particularly over the Kashmir region, have further exacerbated the tensions between India and Pakistan, increasing the likelihood of nuclear escalation.

Both India and Pakistan have justified their nuclear programs as a means of deterring aggression and ensuring national security. However, this has led to a cycle of action and reaction, with each side seeking to maintain a perceived strategic advantage. The absence of a comprehensive regional security framework or nuclear-weapon-free zone (NWFZ) in South Asia has further hindered the development of trust and cooperation among the countries in the region.

Pakistan vs. India military and nuclear powers



*India: including 2 aircraft carriers, 13 destroyers, and 18 submarines / Pakistan: including 8 submarines.

Sources: Newsweek, Global Firepower, Bloomberg, Arms Control Association, the Military Balance 2025 from International Institute for Strategic Studies (IISS), Indian Ministry of Defence (MoD), Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI)



Threats posed by VNSAs in the region

The presence of violent non-state actors (VNSAs), such as terrorist groups, in the South Asia region raises significant concerns about the potential for nuclear materials or technology to fall into their hands. This could further exacerbate the risk of nuclear proliferation and the possibility of a nuclear attack.

According to a report by the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism (UNOCT), groups like Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) and Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), which have been active in the region, have expressed interest in acquiring nuclear weapons or radiological dispersal devices (dirty bombs). The possibility of these groups obtaining nuclear materials or technology from insiders within Pakistan's nuclear program is a major concern, as it could undermine regional and global security efforts.

The threat posed by VNSAs is particularly acute in the South Asia region due to the presence of ongoing conflicts, political instability, and weak governance in some areas. The porous borders, lack of effective border controls, and the potential for corruption within nuclear facilities and programs heighten the risk of nuclear materials or technology being diverted to these groups.

Addressing the threat of VNSAs acquiring nuclear capabilities requires a comprehensive and coordinated approach involving regional and international cooperation, enhanced security measures, and efforts to address the root causes of extremism and terrorism in the region. Failure to effectively mitigate this threat could have catastrophic consequences for regional and global stability.

The international community has taken steps to address the threat of nuclear terrorism, such as the adoption of UN Security Council Resolution 1540 (2004), which obliges states to establish domestic controls to prevent the proliferation of nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons and their means of delivery. However, the implementation of this resolution has been uneven, particularly in regions like South Asia where concerns about national sovereignty and the perceived intrusiveness of monitoring mechanisms have hindered cooperation.

Strengthening international cooperation, intelligence-sharing, and the



development of robust physical security and accounting measures for nuclear materials and facilities are crucial in mitigating the risk of nuclear terrorism in the South Asia region. Addressing the underlying drivers of extremism and promoting regional stability and cooperation are also essential components of a comprehensive approach to this challenge.

Role of IAEA & NSG in de-escalating the tensions

The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) plays a crucial role in monitoring and verifying the peaceful use of nuclear energy by its member states. The IAEA safeguards system helps ensure that nuclear materials and facilities are not diverted for the production of nuclear weapons, making it an essential component of the global non-proliferation regime.

In the context of South Asia, the IAEA's role in providing technical assistance, conducting inspections, and promoting transparency can contribute to deescalating regional tensions and reducing the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation. By ensuring compliance with international norms and standards, the IAEA can help build confidence among the countries in the region and facilitate dialogue on nuclear-related issues.

The Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) is another important international organization that can play a role in deescalating tensions in South Asia. The NSG is a group of nuclear supplier countries that maintain export guidelines for nuclear-related materials and technology, with the aim of preventing nuclear exports for military purposes and ensuring that nuclear trade for peaceful purposes does not contribute to the proliferation of nuclear weapons.

By maintaining strict export controls and promoting the peaceful use of nuclear technology, the NSG can help mitigate the risk of nuclear materials or technology being diverted for military purposes in the South Asia region. Additionally, the NSG's engagement with the countries in the region can foster cooperation and build trust, which can contribute



to the overall efforts towards nuclear non-proliferation and disarmament.

However, the effectiveness of the IAEA and the NSG in deescalating tensions in South Asia is contingent on the willingness of the countries in the region to cooperate and comply with international norms and standards. The complex geopolitical dynamics and the presence of nuclear-armed states in the region pose significant challenges that require a comprehensive and collaborative approach involving these international organizations, the countries in the region, and the broader international community.

India's Nuclear Doctrine

India's doctrine, first drafted in a 1999 draft nuclear doctrine and formally adopted by the Cabinet Committee on Security in January 2003, rests on four central pillars: a policy of No First Use (NFU); a posture of Credible Minimum Deterrence, meaning India seeks an arsenal sufficient to deter rather than to match any adversary weapon-for-weapon; civilian control of the arsenal through the Nuclear Command Authority, chaired by the Prime Minister; and a declared commitment of massive retaliation against any state that does use nuclear, biological, or chemical weapons against India or Indian forces anywhere.

India's No First Use pledge has always carried one significant caveat: it does not apply in the event of a major biological or chemical weapons attack against India, in which case India reserves the right to respond with nuclear weapons. Beyond this, senior Indian officials including former Defence Minister Manohar Parrikar in 2016 and National Security Advisor Ajit Doval more recently, have periodically suggested that NFU should not be treated as an unconditional constraint, introducing an element of strategic ambiguity that many analysts believe is deliberate: it preserves flexibility while avoiding the political and diplomatic cost of a formal doctrinal reversal.

Operation Sindoor did not involve any nuclear signalling by India, and Indian officials and independent analysts alike have described this as a deliberate demonstration that meaningful conventional military action against Pakistan remains possible without triggering nuclear escalation,



what Indian Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan described afterward as considerable “space for conventional operations” beneath the nuclear threshold. Some Indian strategic commentary since the operation has gone further, arguing that India has effectively “called Pakistan's nuclear bluff” and demonstrated that Pakistan's doctrine cannot indefinitely shield cross-border militancy from conventional retaliation.

Pakistan’s Nuclear Doctrine

Pakistan has never issued a single authoritative public doctrine document comparable to India's 2003 statement, relying instead on official statements, red-line signalling by senior officials, and a posture generally described as Full Spectrum Deterrence, formally articulated by then-Strategic Plans Division chief Lt. Gen. Khalid Kidwai in 2015 as a doctrine intended to deter and, if necessary, respond to threats across the entire spectrum of conflict, from full-scale war down to sub-conventional and even limited conventional Indian action.

Unlike India, Pakistan has never adopted a No First Use policy, and deliberately maintains ambiguity about the exact thresholds: territorial, military, economic, or political that would trigger nuclear use. This ambiguity is itself the strategic instrument: by refusing to specify red lines, Pakistan aims to deter not only a full Indian invasion but also more limited Indian conventional responses to sub-conventional provocations (such as militant attacks attributed to Pakistan-based groups), on the theory that India cannot be certain any given level of conventional escalation will not cross an undisclosed threshold.

Pakistan's development and 2011 test of the short-range Nasr (Hatf-IX) missile, widely understood to be intended for battlefield use against advancing Indian armoured formations, marked a significant and controversial doctrinal development: the introduction of tactical, or “battlefield,” nuclear weapons intended for use inside Pakistani territory against invading forces. Critics, including many Western and Indian analysts, argue that battlefield nuclear weapons lower the threshold for nuclear use and create serious command-and-control risks, since forward-deployed tactical weapons must, by design, be more readily



releasable to field commanders than strategic weapons held under tighter centralised control.

Pakistan's Nuclear Command Authority reportedly convened during the May 2025 crisis, an event some analysts characterised as “soft” nuclear signalling intended to remind India and the international community of the stakes involved, even though it did not translate into any explicit nuclear threat or visible force alert. Pakistani officials have since publicly rejected the Indian narrative that its doctrine's deterrent value has been “called out” or diminished, maintaining that Full Spectrum Deterrence functioned as intended by helping bring the conflict to a ceasefire before it escalated further.

Role of China

The unresolved Sino-Indian border dispute, the 1962 war, and periodic subsequent border crises (including a deadly clash in the Galwan Valley in June 2020) mean that Indian nuclear planning has always had to account for a two-front deterrence problem: China and Pakistan simultaneously, that has no equivalent on the Pakistani side. China's relationship with Pakistan compounds this dynamic.

China has been Pakistan's principal defence and nuclear-technology partner for decades, including extensive assistance to Pakistan's civil nuclear power programme (though China maintains that it has not assisted Pakistan's weapons programme directly). During the 2025 crisis, Indian officials, including Deputy Chief of Army Staff Lt. Gen. Rahul Singh, stated publicly that Pakistan's military effort was materially backed by China (and, to a lesser extent, Turkey), a claim that whatever its precise accuracy reflects a widely held Indian perception that any future India-Pakistan crisis cannot be analysed in purely bilateral terms.

China's growing nuclear arsenal, itself expanding more rapidly than at any point in its history according to most independent trackers, adds a further layer of complexity: any Indian risk-reduction posture toward Pakistan must also account for an Indian deterrence relationship with China that operates on entirely separate assumptions and, as yet, has no CBM architecture comparable to what exists between India and Pakistan.



Role of USA and other external actors

The United States has played a consistent, if informal and unacknowledged-by-treaty, crisis-management role in nearly every major India-Pakistan confrontation since 1999: President Clinton's direct intervention ended the Kargil crisis; sustained US diplomatic pressure shaped India's restraint after the 2008 Mumbai attacks; and US involvement, alongside Gulf states including Saudi Arabia and the UAE, was widely credited with helping secure the 10 May 2025 ceasefire that ended Operation Sindoor, though the exact nature and extent of that involvement became a point of dispute afterward, with President Trump publicly claiming the US had brokered the ceasefire and India explicitly pushing back, asserting the ceasefire resulted from direct bilateral military-to-military contact rather than US mediation.

This dispute is not merely rhetorical: it reflects India's longstanding and consistent rejection of third-party mediation on any India-Pakistan matter, a position rooted in the 1972 Simla Agreement, and a genuine tension the committee should recognise between the practical reality that external crisis management has repeatedly helped prevent escalation, and India's principled objection to any external role being formally acknowledged or institutionalised. Other actors with a recurring stake in South Asian crisis management include the Gulf states (particularly Saudi Arabia and the UAE, both of which maintain close relationships with Pakistan and, increasingly with India), the United Kingdom and at the multilateral level, the UN Secretary General, who has in the past issued general calls for restraint during India-Pakistan crises without engaging in direct mediation, respecting India's stated preference for a strictly bilateral resolution process.

What is NPT?

The NPT is a landmark international treaty whose objective is to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons and weapons technology, to promote cooperation in the peaceful uses of nuclear energy and to further the goal of achieving nuclear disarmament and general and complete disarmament. The Treaty represents the only binding commitment in a multilateral treaty to the goal of disarmament by the nuclear-weapon



States. Opened for signature in 1968, the Treaty entered into force in 1970. On 11th May 1995, the Treaty was extended indefinitely.

A total of 191 States have joined the Treaty, including the five nuclear-weapon States. More countries have ratified the NPT than any other arms limitation and disarmament agreement, a testament to the Treaty's significance. The Treaty is regarded as the cornerstone of the global nuclear non-proliferation regime and an essential foundation for the pursuit of nuclear disarmament. It was designed to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons, to further the goals of nuclear disarmament and general and complete disarmament, and to promote cooperation in the peaceful uses of nuclear energy.

To further the goal of non-proliferation and as a confidence-building measure between States parties, the Treaty establishes a safeguards system under the responsibility of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). Safeguards are used to verify compliance with the Treaty through inspections conducted by the IAEA. The Treaty promotes cooperation in the field of peaceful nuclear technology and equal access to this technology for all States parties, while safeguards prevent the diversion of fissile material for weapons use.

Text of the Treaty

<https://treaties.unoda.org/t/npt>

What are Security Assurances?

A security assurance is a commitment designed to reassure a State about a particular security risk. In nuclear diplomacy, the phrase generally refers to commitments made by nuclear-weapon States concerning how and when they will use nuclear weapons, and to commitments to assist non-nuclear States if nuclear aggression occurs. The expression is not a single legal category. Its legal force depends on its source: treaty, Security Council resolution, unilateral declaration, alliance instrument, regional protocol or political statement.

For an NNWS, an assurance has value only if it changes the expected consequences of remaining non-nuclear. If a State believes that abandoning nuclear weapons leaves it exposed to nuclear coercion, a



promise of non-use can reduce the perceived security gap. Conversely, if the promise is highly conditional, revocable, opaque or unsupported by a response mechanism, the State may consider it unreliable.

Security assurances should also be distinguished from arms control. Arms control normally constrains capabilities, numbers, deployment or behaviour between States. An NSA constrains a nuclear State's declared willingness to use a nuclear weapon against a defined class of States. The two overlap because lower arsenals, lower alert levels and risk-reduction measures can make an assurance more credible.

Security assurances also differ from general Charter guarantees. Article 2(4) prohibits the threat or use of force contrary to the Charter, while Article 51 preserves the inherent right of individual or collective self-defence if an armed attack occurs. Neither provision is a nuclear-specific promise by an NWS to an NNWS. The ICJ's 1996 Advisory Opinion treated nuclear threats and use through these general rules, the law of armed conflict and specific nuclear obligations.

Negative assurance: "I will not use or threaten to use nuclear weapons against you, subject to stated conditions."

Positive assurance: "If you suffer or face nuclear aggression, assistance will be provided through specified mechanisms."

Extended deterrence: "A nuclear State may use its nuclear capability to deter attacks against an ally." This can conflict with the logic of universal NSAs.

Security guarantee: broader and often political language; it should not automatically be treated as a legally binding nuclear assurance.

What is the IAEA?

The IAEA was created in 1957 in response to the deep fears and expectations generated by the discoveries and diverse uses of nuclear technology. The Agency's genesis was U.S. President Eisenhower's "Atoms for Peace" address to the General Assembly of the United Nations on 8 December 1953.

The IAEA is strongly linked to nuclear technology and its controversial



applications, either as a weapon or as a practical and useful tool. From the beginning, it was given the mandate to work with its Member States and multiple partners worldwide to promote safe, secure and peaceful nuclear technologies. The objectives of the IAEA's dual mission is to promote and control the Atom, as per the definition in Article II of the IAEA Statute.

IAEA Safeguards

The objective of IAEA Safeguards is to deter the spread of nuclear weapons by the early detection of the misuse of nuclear material or technology. This provides credible assurances that States are honouring their legal obligations that nuclear material is being used only for peaceful purposes.

Safeguards are a set of technical measures applied by the IAEA on nuclear material and activities, through which the Agency seeks to independently verify that nuclear facilities are not misused, and nuclear material not diverted from peaceful uses. States accept these measures through the conclusion of safeguards agreements.

IAEA safeguards are an essential component of the international security system. The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT) is the centrepiece of global efforts to prevent the further spread of nuclear weapons. Under the Treaty's Article 3, each Non-Nuclear Weapon State is required to conclude a safeguards agreement with the IAEA.

The implementation of safeguards follows an annual cycle and comprises four main processes:

Collection and evaluation of safeguards-relevant information

The IAEA collects, processes and reviews all available safeguards-relevant information about a State to evaluate its consistency with the State's declarations about its nuclear programme.

Development of a safeguards approach for a State

A safeguards approach for a State includes those safeguards measures to achieve the technical objectives for verifying the State's declarations.

Planning, conducting and evaluating safeguards activities



The IAEA develops a plan specifying the safeguards activities to be conducted both in the field and at the Agency's headquarters. Once an activity has taken place, the IAEA evaluates the extent to which it has reached the technical objectives and identifies any inconsistencies that might need to be followed up.

Drawing of Safeguards conclusions

The safeguards conclusions drawn by the IAEA are based on its independent verification and findings. They are the final product of the annual safeguards implementation cycle and provide credible assurances to the international community that States are abiding by their safeguards obligations.

Role of the Additional Protocol (INFCIRC/540)

The Additional Protocol (AP) strengthens the standard safeguards system by granting the IAEA expanded rights of access to information and nuclear-related locations beyond declared sites. It was developed in response to the discovery of undeclared nuclear activities in Iraq and is intended to close gaps that CSAs alone cannot address. Under the AP, states must provide broader declarations that include research and development activities, manufacturing of nuclear-related equipment, and nuclear-related trade.

The IAEA is authorized to conduct complementary access to confirm the absence of undeclared nuclear material and activities. Despite its enhanced verification capabilities, the AP is not universally adopted, which undermines its effectiveness. As of 2024, over 140 states have signed and implemented the AP, but key states such as Egypt, Brazil, and Saudi Arabia have not yet brought it into force. Furthermore, the AP is still a voluntary instrument and not a legal requirement under the NPT.

What is a Nuclear-Weapon-Free Zone?

A nuclear-weapon-free zone (NWFZ) is a specified region where countries commit themselves not to manufacture, acquire, test, or possess nuclear weapons. Five such zones exist today, four spanning the



entire Southern Hemisphere.

Legal Definition

According to the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) resolution 3472 B (1975), a NWFZ is “any zone, recognized as such by the General Assembly of the United Nations, which any group of States, in the free exercise of their sovereignty, has established by virtue of a treaty or a convention whereby the statute of total absence of nuclear weapons, to which the zone should be subjected, is defined and an international system of verification and control is established.” Thus, NWFZs involve groups of countries cooperating regionally through multilateral agreements to maintain the denuclearized status of the region.

Treaties Involved in the Nuclear-Weapon-Free Zones

The following treaties form the basis for the existing NWFZs:

Treaty of Tlatelolco (Treaty for the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons in Latin America and the Caribbean)

Treaty of Rarotonga (South Pacific Nuclear Free Zone Treaty)

Treaty of Bangkok (Treaty on the Southeast Asia Nuclear Weapon-Free Zone)

Treaty of Pelindaba (African Nuclear-Weapon-Free Zone Treaty)

Treaty on a Nuclear-Weapon-Free Zone in Central Asia

Other treaties that also deal with the denuclearization of certain areas are:

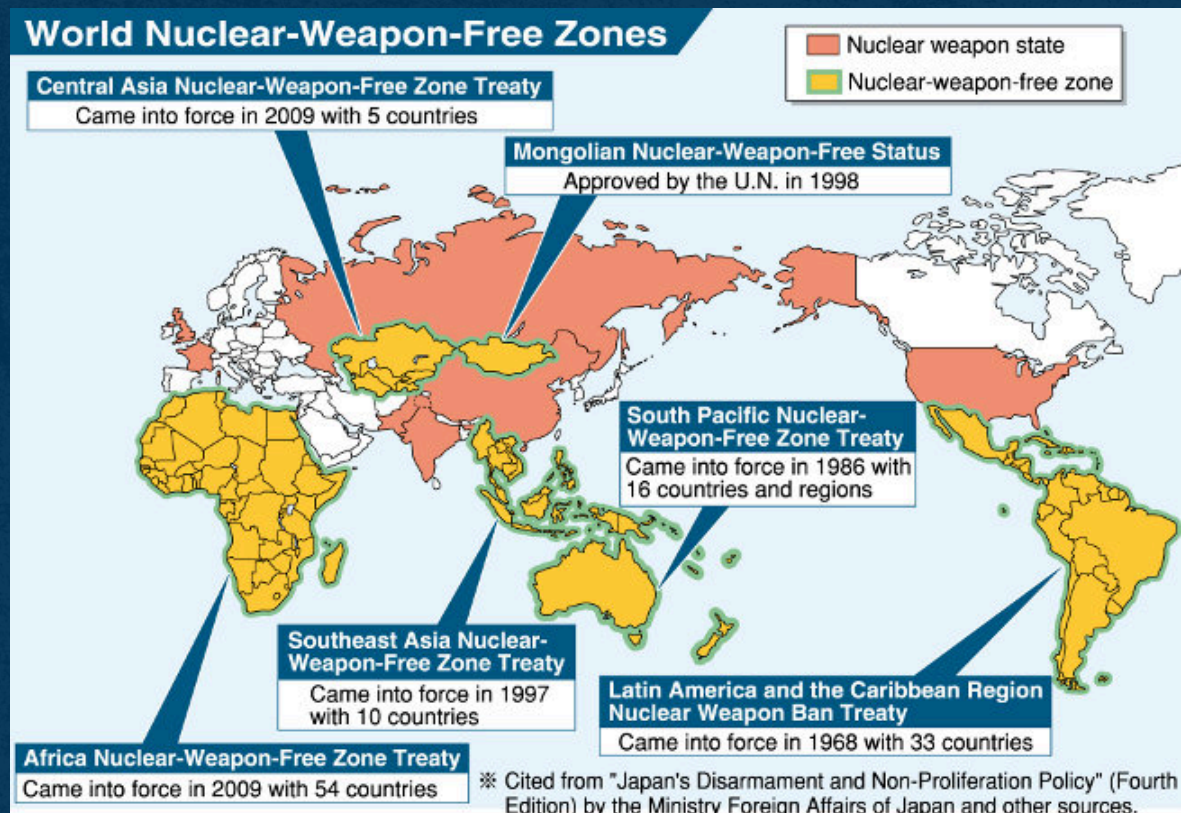
Antarctic Treaty

Outer Space Treaty - Treaty on Principles Governing the Activities of States in the Exploration and Use of Outer Space, including the Moon and Other Celestial Bodies

Moon Agreement - Agreement Governing the Activities of States on the Moon and Other Celestial Bodies



Seabed Treaty - Treaty on the Prohibition of the Emplacement of Nuclear Weapons and Other Weapons of Mass Destruction on the Sea-Bed and the Ocean Floor and in the Subsoil Thereof



Scope for the implementation of a NWFZ in South Asia

The idea of a nuclear weapon free zone in South Asia is not new, and its history reveals as much about the region's mistrust as it does about the concept's technical merits. Pakistan first floated the proposal in 1972, well before either country had tested a weapon, and the timing was not incidental. Islamabad's own weapons program was already underway, and the proposal functioned as much as a diplomatic cover and an image of restraint as it did a genuine disarmament initiative.

India, for its part, rejected the proposal on the grounds that it was not authentically regional. Pakistan's plan excluded China, and India's then Defence Minister C. Subramaniam argued that a zone confined to South Asia while ignoring the wider nuclear neighbourhood would effectively legitimize the weapons held by existing nuclear powers rather than



advance disarmament, reducing the proposal to an extension of the NPT's own asymmetries rather than a genuine alternative to them. India's refusal to explicitly cite China as the reason, choosing instead to argue that South Asia was not a coherent geographic or political unit in the way Latin America was, only partially masked the underlying calculation that any credible security arrangement for the region had to account for Beijing.

The tests of May 1998 closed off whatever residual life the nuclear weapon free zone concept still had, and the international reaction, ranging from condemnation to sanctions, did little to reverse the trajectory both states had already chosen. The episode confirmed what India had argued for two decades: that its nuclear posture could not be addressed as a purely regional matter, since China's role was inseparable from any solution to South Asian security. It also exposed the limits of Pakistan's own sincerity on this front, since its refusal to reciprocate India's no first use pledge, citing India's conventional superiority, sat uneasily alongside its earlier rhetoric of seeking peace through denuclearization.

These historical dynamics still shape why a nuclear weapon free zone remains structurally difficult to revive today. Any such zone would require legally binding commitments from India and Pakistan to forgo the development, testing, and possession of nuclear weapons, but the unresolved territorial disputes between them and the absence of a comprehensive regional security framework make that commitment difficult to extract from either side. Both countries have historically been unwilling to relinquish their nuclear capabilities on national security grounds, and reaching consensus on what the terms of such an agreement should even look like, let alone implementing one, has proven elusive.

None of this makes the goal unworthy of pursuit. A nuclear weapon free zone, if it could ever be constructed on terms both states accepted, and with the meaningful participation of outside nuclear powers whose involvement the region's geography makes indispensable, holds real potential to reduce regional tensions, strengthen security, and contribute to broader global disarmament efforts. But the lesson of the last five decades is that any successful attempt will have to move past



the diplomatic manoeuvring that characterized earlier proposals and instead build a framework that addresses the region's actual geopolitical complexity and earns the trust of all parties whose participation it depends on.

States outside the NPT

As of 2026, the four UN Member States that have never joined the NPT are India, Pakistan, Israel and South Sudan. DPRK is a separate case because it acceded to the NPT and announced withdrawal in 2003; the legal status of that withdrawal has remained contested in international practice. These cases must not be collapsed into one category.

India refused to join the NPT at its inception, objecting to the discriminatory NWS/NNWS categorization, and conducted its first "peaceful nuclear explosion" in 1974 (Pokhran-I) before openly declaring nuclear-weapon status after its 1998 Pokhran-II tests. There have been periodic domestic signals of a possible policy review: in August 2019, then-Defence Minister Rajnath Singh publicly noted that while India had "strictly adhered" to NFU, "what happens in future depends on the circumstances," triggering speculation (not confirmed by any formal policy change) about a possible move away from a firm NFU commitment.

India is a nuclear-armed State outside the NPT. Its 2003 nuclear doctrine states a policy of no first use, a credible minimum deterrent, and non-use of nuclear weapons against non-nuclear-weapon States, while retaining an exception for a major biological or chemical attack. India therefore demonstrates that a non-NPT nuclear State can make an NSA-type commitment without being an NPT NWS.

Pakistan is also outside the NPT and does not maintain a publicly declared no-first-use policy comparable to India's. Its doctrine emphasizes deterrence against India and includes a deliberate degree of ambiguity. This posture, termed "full spectrum deterrence," was formally announced in 2011 following Pakistan's first flight test of the short-range Nasr (Hatf-9) tactical nuclear missile, and is designed to offset India's larger conventional military by threatening early nuclear use including tactical, battlefield-range weapons, against a conventional Indian



offensive before it can penetrate deep into Pakistani territory. This makes Pakistan especially relevant to the question of whether a universal NSA should cover non-NPT nuclear-armed States.

The absence of binding NPT obligations means both states are legally unconstrained by Article VI (disarmament) or Article I/II (non-transfer), undermining global non-proliferation norms. Both continue to modernize their arsenals, but India is developing MIRVs and enhancing sea-based deterrence, whereas Pakistan is deploying tactical nuclear weapons (TNWs) such as the Nasr missile to counter India's Cold Start doctrine.

Israel is outside the NPT and maintains a policy of nuclear opacity known in Hebrew as 'amimut', neither officially confirming nor denying possession. The policy has its roots in the covert construction of the Dimona reactor complex (with French assistance) in the 1950s and 1960s, and has been sustained across nearly seven decades despite the fact that, as independent analysts widely note, there is little genuine ambiguity remaining internationally about the underlying reality of Israel's arsenal. Israel has never joined the NPT, and its Dimona facility has not been subject to IAEA safeguards inspections since the 1960s.

South Sudan, meanwhile, is non-nuclear and outside the NPT; its inclusion is important because an agenda limited to "NPT NNWS" would not protect every non-nuclear State. It currently does not possess any Nuclear Weapons.

North Korea's trajectory is the most legally contested. It acceded to the NPT in 1985, but its relationship with the Treaty has been marked by two withdrawal episodes. The matter was referred to the UN Security Council, but action was blocked by disagreements among the Permanent Five, notably differences between China and the United States over how to respond, leaving the Council without a clear collective position on North Korea's continued treaty status.

A 2013 law first codified conditions for potential first use. A September 2022 law significantly expanded this list of conditions and, for the first time, specified that a nuclear strike would be launched "automatically and immediately" according to a pre-decided operation plan if North Korea's leadership or command-and-control apparatus is placed in



danger by an attack, a "dead hand" style pre-emptive/retaliatory provision aimed at deterring decapitation strikes. Kim Jong Un stated at the time that the law made North Korea's status as a nuclear state "irreversible," explicitly ruling out negotiations over denuclearization.

By late 2023, Kim further redefined inter-Korean relations as being between "two hostile states," and stated North Korea would use nuclear forces in the event of war to bring the entire Korean Peninsula under its control, a significant rhetorical shift from earlier framings centered on deterrence alone. DPRK's case shows the difficulty of withdrawal: a State may seek to exit a treaty while retaining a nuclear capability, raising questions about whether a future NSA treaty should survive withdrawal, be conditional on compliance, or apply independently of NPT membership.

2025 ESTIMATED GLOBAL NUCLEAR WARHEAD INVENTORIES

The world's nuclear-armed states possess a combined total of over 12,400 nuclear warheads; nearly 90% belong to Russia and the United States. Approximately 9,700 warheads are in military service, with the rest awaiting dismantlement.



Source: Federation of American Scientists, U.S. Department of State, U.S. Department of Energy, U.S. Department of Defense, and the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute. Updated: January 2025

Arms Control
Association

Relevant International Framework



Legal Instruments:

Charter of the United Nations

Geneva Conventions (1949)

Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT)

International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) Safeguards

Comprehensive Nuclear Test Ban Treaty (CTBT)

Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA)

Fissile Material Cutoff Treaty (FMCT)

IAEA Statute

The Lahore Declaration and MOU (1999)

The Pre-Notification of Ballistic Missile Tests Agreement (2005)

Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) Guidelines

International Court of Justice. Legality of the Threat or Use of Nuclear Weapons, Advisory Opinion, 8 July 1996

ILC: Guiding Principles applicable to unilateral declarations of States capable of creating legal obligations, 2006

2026 NPT Review Conference background and preparatory documents

2022 Nuclear Posture Review and associated official releases

Conclusion

As this committee undertakes deliberation on this agenda, delegates should prioritize reaffirming the existing framework of India-Pakistan nuclear risk reduction agreements, while exploring innovative mechanisms to prevent miscalculation and inadvertent escalation between two nuclear armed neighbours operating under no formal arms control regime. The May 2025 war demonstrated that conventional conflict, cyber operations and nuclear signalling can now unfold simultaneously rather than in sequence, and the subsequent suspension of the Indus Waters Treaty showed how quickly non-nuclear agreements



can become entangled with the nuclear relationship once trust breaks down.

Each of these developments tests a different part of the existing bilateral architecture, and each suggests that the current framework, however durable it has proven over previous decades, is struggling to keep pace with the speed and complexity of contemporary crises. Equal attention should be given to the structural asymmetries that any risk reduction proposal must eventually confront, including the doctrinal gap between India's evolving posture and Pakistan's full spectrum deterrence, and the unavoidable question of China's role in any arrangement that aims to be more than symbolic. The Executive Board urges the delegates committee to also consider the protection of nuclear command and control systems from cyber intrusion, and the long term viability of regional disarmament frameworks in a security environment that has grown more volatile.

Questions a Resolution must Answer (QARMA)

What realistic risk-reduction measures can be proposed between India and Pakistan that do not require either state to alter its underlying nuclear doctrine or accept third-party mediation of Kashmir?

Should the committee call for new CBMs specifically addressing tactical nuclear weapons and cyber threats to command-and-control systems?

How should the international community respond to the suspension of the Indus Waters Treaty, and should water security be treated as a parallel track to nuclear risk reduction?

Should DISEC encourage renewed India-Pakistan Expert Level Dialogue on Nuclear CBMs, and what role can UNIDIR or other UN technical bodies play in supporting it without appearing to mediate?

How should the committee address the continued absence of India and Pakistan from the NPT, CTBT and FMCT negotiations, given that neither is likely to accede on current terms?

How should China's nuclear relationship with both India and Pakistan



play in a resolution focused on bilateral India-Pakistan risk reduction?

How should the resolution address India's ongoing debate over revisiting its No First Use policy, and what regional consequences follow if that doctrine is formally revised?

Is a South Asian Nuclear Weapon Free Zone a viable long-term goal, and if so, what preconditions, sequencing, or confidence-building steps would need to precede it?